



Reckoning with inheritance: Decolonising group analysis through Afrikan knowledge systems

Matthew Rich-Tolsma

To cite this article: Matthew Rich-Tolsma (02 Jun 2026): Reckoning with inheritance: Decolonising group analysis through Afrikan knowledge systems, European Journal of Psychotherapy & Counselling, DOI: [10.1080/13642537.2026.2666025](https://doi.org/10.1080/13642537.2026.2666025)

To link to this article: <https://doi.org/10.1080/13642537.2026.2666025>



Published online: 02 Jun 2026.



Submit your article to this journal [↗](#)



Article views: 16



View related articles [↗](#)



View Crossmark data [↗](#)



Reckoning with inheritance: Decolonising group analysis through Afrikan knowledge systems

Matthew Rich-Tolsma

Institute of Group Analysis, Academy of Theatre and Dance, ArtEZ University of the Arts

ABSTRACT

This essay explores what it might mean to decolonise group analysis through an encounter with Afrikan knowledge systems, written from the position of an implicated subject – a white Afrikaner psychotherapist, living in Europe, reckoning with complicity and loss. Weaving theoretical critique with clinical and community vignettes, it considers how decolonial thought reshapes analytic practice. The essay begins by situating group analysis within its European origins and the structures of coloniality, drawing on Fanon, Spivak, and Santos to highlight the silences and exclusions that persist in analytic discourse. It then turns to Afrikan epistemologies as generative resources: ubuntu reorients recognition as collective responsibility; sankofa reframes silence as a site of return rather than resistance. These dynamics are illustrated through a therapy group's struggle with the misrecognition of a trans woman, and through reconciliation dialogues between elders and youth in a community scarred by violence. Finally, the essay considers implications for training and institutions, emphasising reflexivity, an expanded clinical frame, and a pedagogy willing to linger with paradox, opacity (Glissant's right not to be fully transparent), and discomfort. Group analysis, renewed through Afrikan thought, is framed not as resolution but as an unfinished praxis of becoming-with others.

Abrechnung mit dem Erbe: Dekolonisierung der Gruppenanalyse durch afrikanische Wissenssysteme

ABSTRAKT

Dieser Aufsatz untersucht, was es bedeuten könnte, die Gruppenanalyse zu dekolonisieren, durch eine Begegnung mit afrikanischen Wissenssystemen, geschrieben im Schatten kolonialer Erbschaften. Aus der Perspektive eines betroffenen Subjekts verwebt er theoretische Kritik mit klinischen und gemeindebasierten Vignetten, um zu überlegen, wie dekoloniales Denken die analytische Praxis umgestalten kann.

Der Aufsatz beginnt damit, die Gruppenanalyse in ihren europäischen Ursprüngen und den fortlaufenden Strukturen der Kolonialität zu verorten, wobei er sich auf Fanon, Spivak und Santos stützt, um die Stille und Ausschlüsse hervorzuheben, die im analytischen Diskurs weiterhin bestehen. Anschließend wendet er sich afrikanischen Erkenntnistheologien als generative

Ressourcen zu, indem gezeigt wird, wie Ubuntu die Anerkennung als kollektive Verantwortung neu ausrichtet und wie Sankofa Stille als einen Ort der Rückkehr statt des Widerstands umrahmt.

Diese Dynamiken werden durch den Kampf einer Therapiegruppe mit der Nichtanerkennung einer Transfrau sowie durch Versöhnungsdialoge zwischen Älteren und Jugendlichen in einer von Gewalt geprägten Gemeinschaft veranschaulicht.

Schließlich betrachtet der Aufsatz die Auswirkungen auf Ausbildung und Institutionen und betont Reflexivität, einen erweiterten Rahmen des Klinischen und eine Pädagogik, die bereit ist, bei Paradoxien, Undurchsichtigkeit und Unbehagen zu verweilen. Die Gruppenanalyse, erneuert durch afrikanisches Denken, wird nicht als Lösung, sondern als eine unvollendete Praxis des Mit-Anderen-Werdens dargestellt.

Haciendo cuentas con la herencia: Descolonizando el análisis grupal a través de los sistemas de conocimiento Afrikan

RESUMEN

Este ensayo explora lo que podría significar descolonizar el análisis de grupo a través de un encuentro con los sistemas de conocimiento Afrikan, escrito a la sombra de las herencias coloniales. Desde la posición de un sujeto implicado, entrelaza la crítica teórica con viñetas clínicas y comunitarias para considerar cómo el pensamiento decolonial remodela la práctica analítica. El ensayo comienza situando el análisis grupal dentro de sus orígenes europeos y las estructuras continuas de colonialidad, recurriendo a Fanon, Spivak y Santos para resaltar los silencios y exclusiones que persisten en el discurso analítico. Luego se dirige a las epistemologías Afrikan como recursos generativos, mostrando cómo el ubuntu reorienta el reconocimiento como una responsabilidad colectiva y cómo el sankofa replantea el silencio como un sitio de retorno en lugar de resistencia. Estas dinámicas se ilustran a través de la lucha de un grupo de terapia con el desconocimiento de una mujer trans, y mediante diálogos de reconciliación entre mayores y jóvenes en una comunidad marcada por la violencia. Finalmente, el ensayo considera las implicaciones para la capacitación y las instituciones, enfatizando la reflexividad, un marco ampliado de lo clínico y una pedagogía dispuesta a permanecer con la paradoja, la opacidad y la incomodidad. El análisis de grupo, renovado a través del pensamiento Afrikan, se enmarca no como resolución sino como una praxis inacabada de coexistir con otros.

Fare i conti con l'eredità: decolonizzare la group analysis attraverso i sistemi di conoscenza africani

RIASSUNTO

Questo saggio esplora cosa potrebbe significare decolonizzare l'analisi di gruppo attraverso un incontro con sistemi di conoscenza africani, scritto all'ombra delle eredità coloniali. Dalla posizione di un soggetto implicato, intreccia critica teorica con vignette cliniche e comunitarie per considerare come il pensiero decoloniale rimodelli la pratica analitica. Il saggio inizia collocando l'analisi di gruppo all'interno delle sue origini europee e delle persistenti

strutture della colonialità, richiamandosi a Fanon, Spivak e Santos per mettere in luce i silenzi e le esclusioni che continuano a caratterizzare il discorso analitico. Si rivolge poi alle epistemologie africane come risorse generative, mostrando come l'*ubuntu* riconfiguri il riconoscimento come responsabilità collettiva e come il *sankofa* riformuli il silenzio come luogo di ritorno piuttosto che di resistenza. Queste dinamiche sono illustrate attraverso la difficoltà, all'interno di un gruppo terapeutico, nel riconoscere adeguatamente una donna trans, e attraverso dialoghi di riconciliazione tra anziani e giovani in una comunità segnata dalla violenza. Infine, il saggio considera le implicazioni per la formazione e per le istituzioni, sottolineando la riflessività, un ampliamento del setting clinico e una pedagogia disposta a sostenere nel paradosso, nell'opacità e nel disagio. L'analisi di gruppo, rinnovata attraverso il pensiero africano, è presentata non come una risoluzione, ma come una prassi incompiuta di *divenire-con* gli altri.

Se confronter à l'héritage : Décoloniser l'analyse de groupe à travers les systèmes de savoir africains

ABSTRAIT

Cet essai explore la décolonisation de l'analyse de groupe à travers une rencontre avec les systèmes de savoir africains, écrits dans l'ombre des héritages coloniaux. Du point de vue d'un sujet impliqué, il entrelace critique théorique et vignettes cliniques et communautaires pour examiner comment la pensée décoloniale remodèle la pratique analytique. L'essai commence par situer l'analyse de groupe dans ses origines européennes et les structures persistantes de la colonialité, en s'appuyant sur Fanon, Spivak et Santos pour mettre en lumière les silences et les exclusions qui persistent dans le discours analytique. Il se tourne ensuite vers les épistémologies africaines comme ressources génératrices, montrant comment l'*ubuntu* réoriente la reconnaissance comme une responsabilité collective et comment le *sankofa* redéfinit le silence comme un lieu de retour plutôt que de résistance. Ces dynamiques sont illustrées par la lutte d'un groupe de thérapie face à la méconnaissance d'une femme transgenre, et par des dialogues de réconciliation entre aînés et jeunes dans une communauté marquée par la violence. Enfin, l'essai examine les implications pour la formation et les institutions, en mettant l'accent sur la réflexivité, un cadre clinique élargi et une pédagogie qui accepte d'explorer le paradoxe, l'opacité et le malaise. L'analyse de groupe, renouvelée par la pensée africaine, est envisagée non comme une résolution, mais comme une pratique inachevée du devenir-avec-autrui.

Αντιμέτωποι με την Κληρονομιά: Από-αποικιοποίηση της Ομαδικής Ανάλυσης μέσω Αφρικανικών Συστημάτων Γνώσης

ΠΕΡΙΛΗΨΗ

Στο παρόν δοκίμιο διερευνάται τρόπους με τους οποίους μπορεί να απο-αποικιοποιηθεί η ομαδική ανάλυση σε συνάρτηση με αφρικανικά συστήματα γνώσης, υπό τη σκιά αποικιακών κληρονομιών. Εδώ συνυφαίνεται η θεωρητική κριτική με αφηγήσεις από κλινικά και

κοινοτικά πλαίσια, προκειμένου να εξεταστεί πώς η απο-αποικιακή σκέψη μπορεί να αναδιαμορφώνει την αναλυτική πρακτική. Το δοκίμιο ξεκινά τοποθετώντας την ομαδική ανάλυση εντός των ευρωπαϊκών της αρχών και των συνεχιζόμενων δομών αποικιοκρατικότητας, αντλώντας από τους Fanon, Spivak και Santos για να αναδείξει τις σιωπές και τους αποκλεισμούς που παραμένουν στον αναλυτικό λόγο. Στη συνέχεια, στρέφεται προς αφρικανικές επιστημολογίες, αναδεικνύοντας πώς το 'ubuntu' επαναπροσδιορίζει την αναγνώριση του άλλου ως συλλογική ευθύνη και πώς το 'sankofa' αναπλαισιώνει τη σιωπή ως επιστροφή στις ρίζες και όχι ως αντίσταση. Οι δυναμικές αυτές αναδεικνύονται μέσα από τη διαμάχη σε μια θεραπευτική ομάδα με την εσφαλμένη αναγνώριση μιας τρανς γυναίκας), καθώς και μέσα από συμφιλιωτικούς διαλόγους μεταξύ πρεσβυτέρων και νέων σε μια κοινότητα σηματοδευμένη από βία. Τέλος, το δοκίμιο εξετάζει τις επιπτώσεις για την εκπαίδευση και τα θεσμικά πλαίσια, δίνοντας έμφαση στην αναστοχαστικότητα, σε ένα διευρυμένο πλαίσιο του κλινικού, και σε μια παιδαγωγική πρόθυμη να παραμείνει με το παράδοξο, την αδιαφάνεια και τη δυσφορία. Η ομαδική ανάλυση, ανανεωμένη μέσω της αφρικανικής σκέψης, προσεγγίζεται όχι ως επίλυση αλλά ως μια ανολοκλήρωτη πράξη του σχεσιακού-γίγνεσθαι.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 15 September 2025; Accepted 2 March 2026

KEYWORDS Group analysis; decoloniality; ubuntu; Afrikan philosophy; psychotherapy training; epistemic justice

SCHLÜSSELWÖRTER Gruppenanalyse; Dekolonialität; Ubuntu; afrikanische Philosophie; relationale Psychoanalyse; Psychotherapieausbildung

PALABRAS CLAVE análisis de grupo; decolonialidad; ubuntu; filosofía Afrikan; psicoanálisis relacional; formación en psicoterapia

PAROLE CHIAVE Group analysis; decolonialità; ubuntu; filosofia africana; psicoanalisi relazionale; formazione in psicoterapia

MOTS-CLÉS Analyse de groupe; décolonialité; ubuntu; philosophie africaine; psychanalyse relationnelle; formation en psychothérapie

ΛΕΞΕΙΣ-ΚΛΕΙΔΙΑ ομαδική ανάλυση; απο-αποικιακότητα; ubuntu; αφρικανική φιλοσοφία; σχεσιακή ψυχάνάλυση; ψυχοθεραπευτική εκπαίδευση

I do not remember much about my oupa, who died when I was a young boy. I remember his hands. Large. Sun-blasted. Square. Calloused. Hands that stuffed pipes and loaded guns. Hands that skinned springbok, salting the fillet and hanging it in long strips. Hands that carved solitude's slow silence in a dusty workshop. They were also hands stained with blood. My oupa was a hunter, a soldier, an apartheid policeman who enforced a racial order built on violence and dispossession. His hands were a site of creativity and brutality in equal measure.

How do I write about decoloniality without facing these inheritances – blood carried and blood spilled? What counts as 'method' if I refuse that reckoning?

This essay is therefore not only about theory, but about what it means to be human together in the shadow of coloniality. To write decolonially is to reckon with the past in the very movement of becoming, to face the stains on our hands as well as their capacity to create. If we want to take this conversation seriously then this is not an indulgence; it is a method.

I am not outside this. I feel the tug of loyalty and shame in equal measure. As Rothberg (2019) insists, we are all ‘implicated subjects’, enmeshed in structures of violence that we did not choose but nevertheless inhabit. As an Afrikaner, this means that my method is inseparable from my becoming. Encountering Afrikan¹ knowledge systems is encountering myself, with all the contradictions, complicities, and wounds that entails.

Afrikan philosophers have long insisted that human beings come into existence only through relation. One clear example of this is the Bantu philosophy of ubuntu. Ubuntu names a broadly held Afrikan relational ontology in which personhood is realised through the recognition and care of others, and is therefore always communal, processual, and ethically binding (Mbiti, 1969; Metz, 2011; Praeg, 2014; Ramose, 2002). Mbiti (1969) captured this with his well-known phrase, ‘I am because we are, and since we are, therefore I am’ (p. 108). Ramose (2002) develops this further, arguing that ubuntu is not a static doctrine but an ongoing practice of becoming human in community, always processual, always unfinished. To invoke ubuntu in the context of psychotherapy is therefore not a gesture of cultural ornamentation but an ontological declaration and methodological demand. Group analysis offers fertile ground for this work. It was born in the UK, shaped by the Kleinian tradition, but its early life was shaped by the Frankfurt school and the horrors of the Holocaust. Group analysis grew out of displacement and loss, then took root in England (Dalal, 2001; Hopper & Weinberg, 2007). That history lives in the method. So do its silences.

This essay asks: *How can group analysis be decolonised through an encounter with Afrikan knowledge systems such as ubuntu and sankofa?* I approach this question as both a psychotherapist and an implicated subject, drawing on personal inheritance, clinical practice, and theoretical reflection.

The essay unfolds in three parts. Part I situates group analysis within the wider frame of coloniality, tracing its origins in European modernity and considering what it means to decolonise through an encounter with Afrikan knowledge systems. Part II turns more explicitly to ubuntu and sankofa, exploring how these epistemologies can illuminate embodiment, trauma, and relation in the analytic group. Part III considers implications for contemporary psychotherapeutic training and practice, asking how we might hold the paradoxes of identity, history, and community in ways that sustain a more just and relationally attuned psychotherapy.

While I focus on ubuntu and sankofa as particular Afrikan resources, my intention is illustrative rather than exhaustive: to show how decolonial epistemologies more broadly can interrupt inherited assumptions in group analysis and open the analytic field to other ontological and ethical horizons.

Part I: Group analysis, coloniality, and decolonial currents

What might it mean to decolonise psychotherapy? Mignolo (2011) offers an important distinction. He differentiates between de-westernisation – geopolitical shifts that challenge Western dominance while leaving its categories intact – and decoloniality, which calls for delinking from Eurocentric epistemologies altogether. Decoloniality invites us to imagine a pluriversal world where many ways of knowing and being coexist. To decolonise group analysis, then, is not simply to reform the field but to question its foundations and open it to other epistemic horizons.

Decolonial thinkers insist that coloniality is not a closed chapter but a structure that continues to shape the present. Quijano (2000) described the ‘coloniality of power’, Maldonado-Torres (2007) traced the ‘coloniality of being’, and Césaire (1955/2000) argued that colonialism dehumanised both coloniser and colonised. Fanon (1952/2008, 1961/2004) showed how this violence scars the psyche, splitting the self and saturating both body and imagination. Santos (2014) speaks of epistemicide, the destruction of knowledge systems from the Global South. Mbembe (2001, 2003) reminds us that Europe’s own disasters were foreshadowed in the colonies. And Spivak (1988) asked the haunting question: can the subaltern speak, and if so, will they be heard? To approach group analysis decolonially is to take seriously these diagnoses of silencing, erasure, and epistemic violence.

Group analysis itself emerged from within these contradictions. S. H. Foulkes trained in Frankfurt in the 1920s and 1930s, in dialogue with Norbert Elias, Karl Mannheim, Ilse Seglow, and Karl Landauer. Their intellectual constellation embodied a rich sociological imagination but was shattered by fascism. Benjamin and Landauer perished; Elias and Mannheim fled. Out of this rupture came a method attuned to the social nature of the mind (Foulkes, 1964). Yet while fascist trauma shaped its origins, colonial violence was largely unacknowledged. Group analysis bore the marks of exile and persecution but rarely reflected on Europe’s wider colonial entanglements.

Once I noticed that gap, I began to hear it everywhere in what groups would not say, and in what I too hesitated to name. Decolonial and critical perspectives have drawn attention to this absence in group analysis. Dalal (2002, 2018) demonstrates how the discipline universalises Eurocentric assumptions while presenting them as neutral. Aiyegbusi (2021a, 2021b, 2023) describes the ‘white mirror’, in which Black clients are reflected only

through distortions, while whiteness remains unexamined. Kinouani (2021, 2023) insists that racial trauma is constitutive of the analytic encounter, not peripheral to it. Nayak (2014) shows how gestures of inclusion often reinforce exclusion when the underlying norms are left intact.

Santos (2014) calls this abyssal thinking, the invisible line that divides what counts as knowledge from what is erased. In groups, abyssal thinking surfaces when certain experiences – such as racial trauma – are implicitly deemed unspeakable, lying beyond the borders of what the group can recognise. Spivak's (1988) provocation, 'Can the subaltern speak?', echoes here. Even when marginalised voices enter the group, they may be heard only through dominant frames, their meaning domesticated rather than received on its own terms. Édouard Glissant (1997) adds another dimension through his insistence on the right to opacity. Against the colonial demand for transparency, Glissant argues that not all that is real can or should be made fully knowable. This complicates the analytic task, when we consider that silence and ambiguity may at times signify not lack, but the presence of something irreducibly resistant to dominant frames of recognition.

These critiques are not only theoretical; they are visible in the lived dynamics of groups. In one analytic group, a Black woman described walking home at night when she realised she was being followed by a group of white young men in hoodies who seemed drunk. She felt her body tighten. Terrified, she imagined in detail the possibility of being attacked and sexually assaulted. Her voice shook as she spoke of fear and anger. The group fell silent. Eventually, an older white female member said, 'I'm sure they were just having fun and meant no harm'. The conversation moved on. Later, the woman said she felt invisible, as though her reality had been brushed aside.

To me, the silence was not empty but saturated, carrying what Hopper (2001) calls the social unconscious: that which is denied yet still shapes the group's life. In my reading, it echoed longer colonial histories, minimising racialised fear while centring white reassurance at the expense of a Black woman's vulnerability. As Fanon (1952/2008) argued in *Black Skin, White Masks*, the racialised subject is caught in the white gaze, objectified and distorted in ways that fracture identity. He also described how the racialised body carries a 'third-person consciousness', an altered body schema imposed by this gaze. The woman's fearful fantasy of attack can be read in this light: colonial violence lived not only as memory but as somatic anticipation in the skin, breath, and imagination. Mbembe's (2003) account of necropolitics offered me one way to think about what was happening in the room, in the sense that the group appeared to be deciding, tacitly, whose fear was 'reasonable' and whose could be smoothed over. The group had, as I experienced it, come up against coloniality but could not yet bear to name it.

Other psychoanalytic frameworks illuminate similar patterns. Hopper's later concept of 'incohesion' (Hopper, 2011) describes how groups fragment

when overwhelmed by trauma. Volkan (1997, 2001) notion of ‘chosen trauma’ shows how collective wounds are transmitted across generations and reactivated in times of crisis. Sheehi and Sheehi (2022) show how psychoanalysis under occupation in Palestine cannot avoid entanglement with colonial violence, revealing both complicity and potential for resistance. These perspectives reveal how social history is always already present in the analytic field.

What might decoloniality offer in response? Afrikan knowledge systems such as ubuntu and sankofa provide crucial resources. Ubuntu is often summarised in the proverb ‘a person is a person through other persons’, yet its philosophical weight is far greater. At its core, ubuntu articulates an ontology of relation. As Ramose (2002) argues, being is never self-sufficient but always ‘becoming-with’, inseparable from the lives of others. Shutte (1993) develops this further, showing that for ubuntu traditions, identity is not a private possession but a shared achievement of mutual recognition.

Later thinkers have highlighted the ethical and political force of this orientation. Eze (2010) frames ubuntu as a dynamic ethic of recognition: to see and affirm the humanity of others is not optional but constitutive of one’s own being. Metz (2007, 2011) builds on this to propose ubuntu as a moral theory, one that grounds justice in relationships of identity and solidarity. For him, the good life is not defined by individual autonomy but by the quality of care and reciprocity in community life. Praeg (2014, 2017) reminds us that ubuntu cannot be reduced to a romanticised harmony. It is a critical philosophy forged in the wake of colonial violence, one that names the fractures in human community and calls for their repair. Ubuntu, in this sense, is as much a political project as it is a moral or ontological one.

Seen together, these voices disclose the radical depth of ubuntu. It is not a decorative slogan but an invitation to rethink what it means to be human. In its insistence that life is constituted in relation, ubuntu speaks directly to Fanon’s vision of decolonisation as the creation of a ‘new humanity’ (1961/2004). For group analysis, it opens the possibility of reimagining the analytic field not as a collection of isolated psyches, but as a matrix of mutual becoming where recognition, repair, and justice are inseparable.

Sankofa, from the Akan tradition, is often represented by the Adinkra symbol of a bird looking backward while flying forward (sometimes retrieving an egg in its beak). It means ‘to return and fetch it’, reminding us that moving ahead requires retrieving what has been left behind. Temple (2010) explains how sankofa contests the linear temporality of Western modernity, calling instead for cyclical engagement with the past. In this sense, sankofa resonates with Santos’s (2014) epistemologies of the South and Mignolo’s (2011) call for delinking. It insists that the way forward is through remembrance and retrieval, not erasure or forgetting. To decolonise group analysis is therefore not to add Afrikan colour to European theory, but to invite

a reconfiguration of our ontological ground in order to disclose the possibility of human life as relational, embodied, and unfinished.

Part II: Encountering Afrikan knowledge systems in group analysis

If critique alerts us to absence, decolonisation also requires presence. It is not enough to expose the silences around coloniality in group analysis. We must also ask how other epistemologies might reshape our practice. Ubuntu and sankofa, already introduced as Afrikan resources, open important paths for thinking about relation, time, and embodiment in groups. What matters here is not repeating their definitions but exploring what they do in the room.

One moment that illustrates this took place in a long-term analytic group within a community mental health project. Femke, a white, working-class trans woman, had been participating for over a year. She was generally liked by other members of the group, and engaged thoughtfully. One afternoon, a man named Frans, a cisgender participant in his late fifties, offered a personal reflection. 'I used to think gender was just about anatomy', he said. 'But after getting to know Femke, I see things differently now'. His tone was gentle and even appreciative, presented as a story of learning. Yet something shifted in the room. Femke's shoulders tensed. There was a pause before she responded. And then came the silence. It was not a silence of reflection, but of avoidance. I could hear the scrape of a chair and the hum of the fluorescent lights. Someone coughed softly. My own jaw had tightened; I realised that I was waiting, perhaps just as others were, for someone else to go first. The group moved on, as if nothing had happened.

To some members of this group, this event might have been imperceptible. For Femke, however, and perhaps for those attuned to these dynamics, Frans's words carried a painful significance. For a trans woman, the reference to anatomy cut to the heart of a painful history in which her identity had so often been reduced to genitals or medicalised debates about the 'realness' of her body. Scholars note that such anatomical reductionism remains a pervasive form of misrecognition, casting trans people as problems to be explained rather than subjects to be encountered in their fullness (Butler, 2004; Serano, 2007). The silence was thick, almost bodily. This brings to mind Hopper's (2001) notion of the social unconscious, as communication that happens through absence as much as through speech. I took the silence less as a pause for thought than as a defensive manoeuvre, shielding the group from confronting what had just been named. It reflected a pattern familiar to many trans people, the troubling experience of being present but not fully recognised and expected at all times to be available to do the psychic labour of managing cis discomfort. Spivak's (1988) provocation 'Can the subaltern speak?' echoes here. Even when Femke spoke, I worried that her

meaning was being absorbed without being metabolised, remaining legible mainly through Frans's 'learning story' rather than on its own terms (Spivak, 1988).

Later, when Femke named her discomfort, the familiar sequence unfolded. I recognised the choreography and the ways in which I was implicated in the unconscious patterning. Frans became defensive, then tearful, then apologetic. 'I didn't mean to hurt you', he said. 'Can you explain what I did wrong so I don't do it again?' What began as Femke's attempt to articulate harm was quickly translated into an emotional demand. She was now asked to reassure the very person who had misrecognised her. Ahmed (2012) describes this redistribution of affective labour as the centring of those with structural power, while the marginalised are perpetually required to contain, educate, and absorb. Femke's credibility as a knower was undermined, her attempt at testimony diverted into labour for others; this might be understood as an epistemic injustice (Fricker, 2007). This apparent gesture towards inclusion left the underlying asymmetries untouched. As Fraser (2009) wisely reminds us, recognition without redistribution is hollow.

I chose to step in. I said what I had seen and felt: that Femke had been made to carry the weight of educating and soothing cisgender discomfort, while the rest of us went quiet. Something had become located between Femke and Frans, but I wanted to draw attention to what was emerging in the group as a whole. I mused about how often trans participants are asked to carry the burden of educating and soothing cisgender discomfort. I wondered aloud about the silence, what it protected, and at what cost. Slowly, others began to speak. They acknowledged hesitation, admitted discomfort, and turned toward Femke, not to ask her to explain, but to witness what had happened. Recognition was redistributed.

Ubuntu offers one way of understanding this shift. If our humanity is bound together, then recognition cannot remain the responsibility of the marginalised alone. To expect Femke to carry the whole weight of the rupture was to diminish the humanity of all. As Ramose (2002) argues, ubuntu is not sentiment but ontology: being is always becoming-with. Praeg (2014) reminds us that this has political weight, calling us to new forms of justice. In practice, ubuntu asks the group to take collective responsibility for recognition, to see each member not as an object in someone else's story of progress but as a subject whose dignity implicates the whole.

A second encounter, in a very different context, showed how ubuntu can reshape group life beyond the consulting room. In Northern Kenya, I worked with a group that included traditional leaders, elders from a rural Afrikan community, and young men who had taken part in a cycle of intra-tribal cattle raids with neighbouring pastoralist groups. These raids had resulted in loss of life and deepening mistrust. We met in a dusty courtyard under acacia shade. Mats on the ground. A dented aluminium jug passed from hand to

hand. The young men sat apart, restless; the elders spoke with slow gravity, invoking history and kinship ties.

At first, the conversation circled around blame. Each side rehearsed grievances, recalling raids, deaths, and betrayals. The risk was that the gathering would collapse into recrimination. Yet as the dialogue deepened, moments of vulnerability emerged. An elder spoke of his grief at losing a nephew. One of the young men admitted he still had nightmares of a killing. The group fell quiet, holding the weight of these confessions. I remember the sound of goats beyond the wall, and the way no one looked at the floor. It was here that ubuntu became palpable, not as a slogan but as a way of orienting the group toward recognition and repair. Archbishop Tutu (1999), the leader of South Africa's celebrated *Truth and Reconciliation Commission*, insisted that restorative justice depends on recognising both the suffering of victims and the humanity of perpetrators. In this Kenyan courtyard, that recognition took shape in the mutual acknowledgment of loss and guilt, of pain and responsibility.

Within a group-analytic frame, the matrix was not only psychological but also cultural and ancestral. The stories of raids and reprisals were not individual narratives but collective memory, carried in the social unconscious of the community. Sankofa resonates here too. To move forward, the group needed to return, to fetch the grief and violence that had been silenced. Only then could reconciliation become possible. Ubuntu's ethic of reconciliation and restoration allowed participants to see that their own healing was bound to the healing of the whole community. The recognition of each person's role, as both part of the problem and part of the solution, was central to the process.

Fanon sharpens the insight. In *Black Skin, White Masks* (1952/2008), he exposed how colonialism deforms recognition and saturates embodiment with fracture. Yet he did not stop at diagnosis. In *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961/2004), he insisted that decolonisation must give birth to a 'new humanity'. Ubuntu resonates here, for it demands that even across rupture, relation be restored if life is to go on. Group analysis, when decolonised through encounter with Afrikan knowledge, can become a resource for this work of reconstitution.

These encounters also raise questions for training. In supervision, I have often been encouraged to 'move the group on' when silence becomes heavy. Yet sankofa suggests that silence may be where something crucial is returning, not resistance to be pushed past, but memory seeking recognition. Cohesion is often taught as harmony or agreement. Ubuntu reframes it as interdependence-with-difference, where recognition of particularity strengthens the field rather than weakening it. The social unconscious, too, can be understood not only as the repressed dynamics of groups but as ancestral, embodied, and communal memory. Training that

acknowledges ubuntu and sankofa would prepare practitioners to listen for these histories, to welcome their return, and to allow them to reshape the analytic field.

If ubuntu and sankofa offer resources for reimagining practice, they also unsettle the structures in which practice is taught and legitimised. Decolonising group analysis therefore confronts us with paradox: between absence and presence, silence and speech, rupture and repair. These tensions are not obstacles but openings, shaping the frameworks through which we teach, train, and practise. It is to these wider implications that I now turn.

Part III: Toward a decolonised praxis of group analysis

Having traced both the silences in group analysis and the possibilities disclosed when Afrikan epistemologies enter the room, I now turn to the implications for training and practice. This requires learning to hold tensions – between absence and presence, history and becoming, identity and relation – in ways that sustain a more just and relationally attuned psychotherapy.

Expanding the frame of the clinical

The group analytic imagination is frequently confined to hospitals and consulting rooms. My experience says otherwise; I am equally interested in bringing group analytic thinking to classrooms, community centres, organisations, and reconciliation circles beneath acacia trees. If the matrix is a web of conscious and unconscious connection, its field is not bounded by walls. I had to unlearn some of my training to see that. If the matrix is a web of conscious and unconscious connection, then its field is not limited by geography or context. What makes a setting ‘clinical’ is not only its institutional label but its commitment to working with unconscious dynamics in the service of recognition, repair, and transformation.

This expanded frame has implications for training. Curricula must prepare practitioners to encounter diversity not as an add-on, but as constitutive of the analytic field. Silence, rupture, and recognition play out differently across contexts marked by colonial history, racialisation, and gendered power. A decolonised training would ask how these dynamics shape the very possibility of analysis, and would cultivate the reflexive capacity to work across porous boundaries between the clinical and the communal. To bring this into training means acknowledging that analytic practice is always communal, even when conducted in a dyad or within the four walls of a consulting room.

Holding paradox

To practise in this way requires holding paradox. As Elias (1987) reminded us, involvement and detachment are not opposites but tensions that must be lived. Decolonial practice requires us to stay involved in histories of oppression and trauma, even as we cultivate enough detachment to think and work with them. Ubuntu itself is paradoxical: as Ramose (2002) and Metz (2011) argue, it calls us to affirm both interdependence and particularity. The self exists only through relation, yet each person is irreducible. Metz (2011) deepens this, proposing that ubuntu can be read as a moral theory in which the good life consists in relationships of identity and solidarity. This is not sentimental harmony but a principled orientation to live in ways that promote the dignity of others while allowing them to remain distinct. Praeg (2014) reinforces this point, showing that ubuntu is not a romantic ideal of cultural authenticity but a political project that demands we live with tension and conflict rather than resolve them prematurely. What if the point is not to fix the tension, but to be changed by staying with it? What becomes possible when we resist the urge to tidy the room?

Sankofa also insists on paradox: to move forward, one must first turn back. For psychotherapy training, this means that progress is not linear. The most generative moments often emerge from what has been avoided or disavowed. Han's (2021) critique of the 'palliative society' resonates here: training that smooths over conflict or silences trauma does not prepare practitioners for the real work of recognition. A decolonised pedagogy must resist the lure of premature closure, cultivating instead the capacity to sit with contradiction, discomfort, and pain.

Reflexivity and the implicated subject

The reflexivity modelled in this essay – beginning with my own reckoning as an Afrikaner implicated in colonial violence – is not a confession but a clinical responsibility. Rothberg's (2019) notion of the implicated subject reminds us that even those who are not direct victims or perpetrators of violence are nevertheless enmeshed in histories of harm. Sankofa offers a complementary orientation: to be reflexive is to 'go back and fetch' the histories we embody, to retrieve what has been silenced or denied in order to live otherwise. Training must therefore move beyond abstract cultural competence toward cultivated reflexivity about one's own positionality. To ask how my identities shape the transference and countertransference is not ancillary to analysis; it is constitutive of it. In practice, this can be small and deeply embodied, such as the way my shoulders rise when my whiteness is named, or how quickly I move to intellectualise when shame flickers.

Decolonial pedagogy requires space for trainees to grapple with their own inheritances – of privilege, marginalisation, complicity, or resistance – and to bring these into dialogue with others. This is a deeply uncomfortable process, but one without which talk of ‘equity’ or ‘diversity’ risks becoming hollow. Ramose (2002) reminds us that ubuntu is a philosophy of justice which demands not only acknowledgement of harm but also reconstitution of relationship. Reflexivity in this key is not self-absorption but responsibility, an orientation to the other through the recognition of our entangled histories.

Rethinking cohesion and silence

The implications extend to core concepts of group analysis itself. Cohesion has often been framed as harmony or agreement. Yet from the perspective of ubuntu, cohesion is not the absence of conflict but the recognition of interdependence even in difference. A group that can acknowledge pain and fracture may in fact be more cohesive than one that silences or denies them. Metz (2011) argues that ubuntu morality is relational but not assimilationist: the good life is realised through caring relations that also respect difference. Praeg (2014) echoes this, stressing that ubuntu’s political potency lies precisely in its refusal to erase contradiction.

Silence too must be rethought. In training, silence is often treated as resistance to be endured. Sankofa reframes silence as a site of return, perhaps to a place where unspeakable histories are pressing at the edges of speech. To hurry past such silence is to collude with avoidance and negation. To linger with it is to allow what was disavowed to find recognition. Édouard Glissant’s (1997) notion of opacity reveals how not all that is present can be rendered transparent to understanding, nor should it be. Opacity affirms that certain aspects of experience remain irreducible, untranslatable, and yet still profoundly relational. In this sense, silence may mark not emptiness but the presence of what resists capture. I have learned to ask quietly (and sometimes aloud): if we do not name this, what or whom are we protecting? The Sankofa bird, looking backward with an egg in its beak, seems to me a fitting symbol for analytic listening, an act of attending not only to what is said, but also to what the body and the field remember, including those dimensions that remain opaque.

Institutional responsibilities

Finally, the implications extend beyond individual training to the institutions that form and regulate psychotherapists. Decolonisation cannot be left to the enthusiasm of individual trainees; it requires institutional transformation. This includes curricula that engage with decolonial and Afrikan

epistemologies, supervision practices that name racialised and gendered dynamics explicitly, and assessment processes that reward reflexivity as much as technical competence.

Institutions must also grapple with their own silences. Which voices are on the reading lists? Who teaches and who is taught? What kinds of knowledge are legitimised and what kinds remain outside the canon? In many European training programmes, Freud, Klein, and Winnicott are standard, while Afrikan philosophers such as Ramose or Fanon, or writers like Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o, are absent. I benefited from this disciplining process and I have also come perilously close to losing part of myself to it. Supervision often addresses transference and countertransference, but rarely names whiteness or coloniality as powerful social currents which are inevitably shaping them. Assessments emphasise technical proficiency but seldom reward vulnerability, positional reflexivity, or the capacity to hold paradox.

Ubuntu offers a corrective orientation: institutions, like persons, are constituted in relation. Their legitimacy depends on recognising and sustaining those at the margins. Tutu's (1999) reflections from South Africa's Truth and Reconciliation Commission remind us that recognition without restoration is incomplete. Institutions that aspire to justice must not only hear testimonies but also redistribute resources, creating spaces where dignity and mutual recognition are structurally sustained.

Conclusion: Toward a more just practice

To decolonise group analysis through an encounter with Afrikan knowledge systems is not to abandon the tradition but to extend it. In this sense, the matrix can be reimagined as a field of mutual becoming whose ethical texture is shaped not only by intrapsychic dynamics but by the histories and power relations that organise recognition and silence. Foulkes' vision of the group as matrix was already a break from individualistic psychotherapy. To take that vision seriously in our time requires attending to the colonial wounds and silenced histories that shape the matrix in every group.

Ubuntu calls us into mutual recognition, where dignity is shared and responsibility for repair is collective. Sankofa reminds us that healing requires return, that the past lives on in the body and in the social unconscious. Together they summon us toward a practice that is more human, more just, and more relationally alive.

This work is praxis: a way of becoming-with others through an iterative social process of action and reflection. As Fanon (1961/2004) insisted, the task of decolonisation is to make possible a new humanity. This work does not end. It is always alive in the present. I return, I listen, I speak, I stay. Our participation is inescapable, and our healing is bound together.

Note

1. I use *Afrikan* (rather than *African*) to signal a decolonial orientation that resists the flattening effects of colonial taxonomy and gestures toward situated, plural, and contested traditions on the continent and in the diaspora. I do not intend the term to imply a singular culture or essence.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on contributor

Matthew Rich-Tolsma is a South African artist-educator, group analyst in training, and organisational consultant based in the Netherlands. He is a Principal Fellow of the Higher Education Academy and a Fellow of the Institute of Educational and Social Equity. He serves as Pedagogue-in-Residence at ArtEZ University of the Arts, and also teaches and supervises research at Tilburg School of Economics and Management. He has extensive consultancy experience across Africa, Europe, and the Middle East, his work integrates group analysis, African knowledge systems, and critical pedagogy. He is in the final year of training with Group Analysis North and runs a small group analytic practice in Amsterdam. He was the winner of the Institute of Group Analysis's 2025 Dennis Brown Prize for Student Writing. He is the convenor of the Foundation Course in Group Analysis at Turvey Groupwork.

References

- Ahmed, S. (2012). *On being included: Racism and diversity in institutional life*. Duke University Press.
- Aiyegbusi, A. (2021a). The white mirror: Face to face with racism in group analysis. Part 1 - Mainly theory. *Group Analysis*, 54(3), 402–420. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0533316421992315>
- Aiyegbusi, A. (2021b). The white mirror: Face to face with racism in group analysis. Part 2 - Mainly practice. *Group Analysis*, 54(3), 421–436. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0533316421992438>
- Aiyegbusi, A. (2023). The white mirror. In E. Hopper (Ed.), *The tripartite matrix in the developing theory and expanding practice of group analysis* (Vol. 4, pp. 121–133). Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003425915-13>
- Butler, J. (2004). *Undoing gender*. Routledge.
- Césaire, A. (2000). *Discourse on colonialism* (J. Pinkham, Trans.) Monthly Review Press. (Original work published 1955)
- Dalal, F. (2001). The social unconscious: A post-Foulkesian perspective. *Group Analysis*, 34(4), 539–555. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0533316401344011>
- Dalal, F. (2002). *Race, colour and the processes of racialization: New perspectives from group analysis, psychoanalysis and sociology*. Brunner-Routledge.
- Dalal, F. (2018). *CBT: The cognitive behavioural tsunami - Managerialism, politics and the corruptions of science*. Routledge.
- Elias, N. (1987). *Involvement and detachment*. Basil Blackwell.

- Eze, M. O. (2010). *Intellectual history in contemporary South Africa*. Palgrave Macmillan.
- Fanon, F. (2004). *The wretched of the earth* (R. Philcox, Trans.) Grove Press. (Original work published 1961)
- Fanon, F. (2008). *Black skin, white masks* (R. Philcox, Trans.) Grove Press. (Original work published 1952)
- Foulkes, S. H. (1964). *Therapeutic group analysis*. George Allen & Unwin.
- Fraser, N. (2009). *Scales of justice: Reimagining political space in a globalizing world*. Columbia University Press.
- Fricker, M. (2007). *Epistemic injustice: Power and the ethics of knowing*. University of Oxford Press.
- Glissant, E. (1997). *Poetics of relation*. University of Michigan Press.
- Han, B.-C. (2021). *The palliative society: Pain today* (D. Steuer, Trans.) Polity.
- Hopper, E. (2001). The social unconscious: Theoretical considerations. *Group Analysis*, 34(1), 9–27. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0533316012207686>
- Hopper, E. (2011). The theory of incohesion: Aggregation/massification as the fourth basic assumption in the unconscious life of groups and group-like social systems. *Group Analysis*, 44(2), 137–157. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0533316410396859>
- Hopper, E., & Weinberg, H. (Eds.). (2007). *The social unconscious in persons, groups and societies: Volume 1*. Karnac.
- Kinouani, G. (2021). *Living while Black: The essential guide to overcoming racial trauma*. Ebury Press.
- Kinouani, G. (2023). *Whiteness, racism and psychotherapy: Critical perspectives on theory and practice*. Routledge.
- Maldonado-Torres, N. (2007). On the colonality of being. *Cultural Studies*, 21(2–3), 240–270. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09502380601162548>
- Mbembe, A. (2001). *On the postcolony*. University of California Press.
- Mbembe, A. (2003). Necropolitics. *Public Culture*, 15(1), 11–40. <https://doi.org/10.1215/08992363-15-1-11>
- Mbiti, J. S. (1969). *African religions and philosophy*. Heinemann.
- Metz, T. (2007). Toward an African moral theory. *The Journal of Political Philosophy*, 15(3), 321–341. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1467-9760.2007.00280.x>
- Metz, T. (2011). Ubuntu as a moral theory and human rights in South Africa. *African Human Rights Law Journal*, 11(2), 532–559.
- Mignolo, W. (2011). *The darker side of Western modernity: Global futures, decolonial options*. Duke University Press.
- Nayak, S. (2014). *Race, gender and the activism of black feminist theory: Working with Audre Lorde*. Routledge.
- Praag, L. (2014). *A report on Ubuntu*. University of KwaZulu-Natal Press.
- Praag, L. (2017). *Ubuntu: Curating the archive*. University of KwaZulu-Natal Press.
- Quijano, A. (2000). Coloniality of power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America. *Nepantla: Views from South*, 1(3), 533–580.
- Ramose, M. B. (2002). The philosophy of ubuntu and ubuntu as a philosophy. In P. H. Coetzee & A. P. J. Roux (Eds.), *The African philosophy reader* (2nd ed., pp. 230–238). Routledge.
- Rothberg, M. (2019). *The implicated subject: Beyond victims and perpetrators*. Stanford University Press.
- Santos, B. D. S. (2014). *Epistemologies of the south: Justice against epistemicide*. Routledge. <https://doi.org/10.4324/9781315634876>

- Serano, J. (2007). *Whipping girl: A transsexual woman on sexism and the scapegoating of femininity*. Seal Press.
- Sheehi, L., & Sheehi, S. (2022). *Psychoanalysis under occupation: Practicing resistance in Palestine*. Routledge.
- Shutte, A. (1993). *Philosophy for Africa*. University of Cape Town Press.
- Spivak, G. C. (1988). Can the subaltern speak? In C. Nelson & L. Grossberg (Eds.), *Marxism and the interpretation of culture* (pp. 271–313). University of Illinois Press.
- Temple, C. N. (2010). Sankofa as a research tool for historical trauma: Reclaiming African worldviews. *Journal of Black Studies*, 41(1), 127–150. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0021934709332464>
- Tutu, D. (1999). *No future without forgiveness*. Doubleday.
- Volkan, V. D. (1997). *Bloodlines: From ethnic pride to ethnic terrorism*. Farrar, Straus and Giroux.
- Volkan, V. D. (2001). Transgenerational transmissions and “chosen traumas”: An aspect of large-group identity. *Group Analysis*, 34(1), 79–97. <https://doi.org/10.1177/05333160122077730>